

Philips SHP9500 open-back headphones

Clear, clinical and comfortably priced

Philips has a really long legacy in the audio space. We had a tape recorder cum radio set from the brand that we treasured for years, even after it stopped being useful. That's the allure the brand holds for many of us, Indians. So, when Philips launched the SHP9500 in India, I was eager to test it. The review unit came in a few weeks back, and I have been using it since then as my primary work headphones. It comes with a long detachable wire and a black open-back design that states its studio headphone aesthetic. I had it sitting over my ears, giving me, spoiler-spoiler, a good time, but much to my colleague's chagrin. But in this course of use, I was trying to find whether the experience justifies the Rs 6,499 price it demands. Come, let me take you through my experience and by the end, you will have the answer.

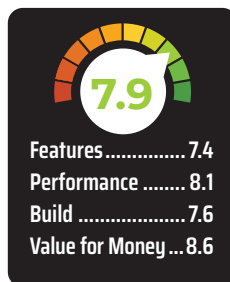
₹6,499



SIMPLE DESIGN AND DECENT COMFORT

The SHP9500 does not try very hard with design. It sticks to a functional and familiar formula: Large circular earcups, a metallic headband with a nice and lustrous finish, some of which gets exposed if you extend it, the metallic open-back grille, but black in colour, and a matte plastic frame. The detachable wire is also black, with the headphone input grey in colour.

There is a Philips logo on the hinges connecting both sides of the headband and earcups. Just so you don't get confused by the side, there are Left and Right markings on the outer surface of the respective earcups and on the inner headband cushion too. These markings



are clearly legible and a thoughtful inclusion.

But, I don't get the point of '50MM Vented Neo-Dymium Drivers' and 'Open Acoustic Architecture' text on both earcups. By design, this pair will be mainly used in a room. It is a very personal product and not something to show off to anyone. That's all, I rest my bickering on this one.

The headphones feel light, and the clamp force is not too tight. The foam cushions are moderately soft, but the padding is thin compared to regular over-ear headphones. The mesh is breathable. This matters for airflow, and even though the material is a bit rough, it was comfortable to wear for hours in an air-conditioned office. But you may

feel the coarseness more noticeably in a non-AC, hot and humid room.

Speaking of comfort, Philips has bundled a really long cable, around 3 meters long. Even while using it on my office desk, at times it would unintentionally get tangled on my chair legs or my human legs. A minor quibble, admittedly. But I get that the length means one can conveniently sit at a distance from the source, without any extender and move around freely, say in a studio.

The cable material is good, and the detachability allows you to connect third-party wires, too. More convenience, my friend, and fewer reasons to complain. There is no built-in mic on the bundled cable. But thanks to the detachability, you can plug in an aftermarket option that suits your needs.

The overall build feels pretty solid. The open-back design leaks sound, and that can annoy people around you. So, like any other open-back headphone, the SHP9500 is meant for quiet environments where others won't be disturbed. The outside noise seeps in. But you can escape that by playing music at a decent loudness without pushing the volume dangerously high.

CLEAR AND RAW SOUND

While I initially cribbed about the 50mm driver and open acoustic architecture branding in the above segment, I have praises for them here. The sound output is clear, present, and comes with a respectable amount of bass and treble. There is ample separation of instruments and vocals, which makes the listening experience genuinely engaging. You can hear what's going on in the track. And the Philips headphones sound plenty loud, too. I didn't have to raise volume beyond 75% or sometimes 80% on my MacBook Air M1.

The presentation is airier than closed-back headphones, but still, there's some enclosure. It is not as wide or expansive as more expensive headphones. But that doesn't take away much from the overall experience.